handed, I throw right-handed, I play tennis right-handed . . . but I bat left-handed. It's so perplexing that Marcus Trescothick has genuinely tried a number of times to see if I'm batting the wrong way round. Each time we leave the nets puzzled and beaten, concluding that I probably was batting the right way round, I just couldn't do it very well. I expend more energy walking back and forth in the dressing room, waiting to bat, than I do in the field sometimes.

What sort of a cruel sport is this where it will make you attempt something you are completely unequipped to do, again and again, forever and ever? What sort of cruel sport leaves you as the last man too, suffering the indignity of everyone preying on your resistance while the rest of your team – some of them batters by trade who have got themselves out – have the audacity to watch on, praying you survive? I wake up at night sometimes, visions of cricket balls flying towards my head, flinching and then sitting bolt upright in bed. *Phew,* I think. *I'm not batting. It's OK. Go back to sleep*. The thing I really can't deal with is the idea that I may have let my teammates down and that there might be one tiny moment amongst millions, a split-second reflex response to a cricket ball with less than half a second to make your move, that I will be regretting forever.

There are two balls remaining. The clapping, the panic, the urgency in between deliveries dies down. The tunnel again encloses. It's a sickening silence as Eranga is about to run in. It's the sort of silence that precedes a vertical drop on a roller coaster. He runs in. I know what to do; it's worked so far. Get back and across and give myself time to jam the bat down on it whether it is full or short. He runs in and delivers with that catapult action I've been finding so hard to read. I'm back and across, but this time it feels twice as fast as anything he's bowled. It's the one that spits out of nowhere. The last sight I have of it is as it spears at my face. I get my bat somewhere near it, but I'm not in control of it. The ball spoons into the air off my bat handle and it feels like it is in the air for the entire duration of the past ten days of cricket. In fact, it feels longer. As Rangana Herath takes the catch, giving Sri Lanka their first ever series win in England, I am bowed, my eyes closed, hunched over. I never want to stand up again, to see sunlight again. I never want to open my eyes. I can hear the wild celebrating of the Sri Lankans and then, more gently, the presence of Moeen Ali, standing